Gregory Polyakov

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Summary

Third-year PhD student at the University of Tübingen and IMPRS-IS working on mechanistic interpretability of language models for NLP and IR. Studies how models implement complex behaviors such as hallucination, in-context learning, and relevance estimation, and turns these findings into methods for controlling and improving them. First author of four papers, including at EMNLP and SIGIR, with three years of industrial experience at Huawei Noah's Ark Lab in production search, LLM tool use, and voice-assistant systems.

Education

University of Tübingen & Max Planck Research School — *Tübingen, Germany*
***PhD** in Computer Science* — *Oct 2024 – Aug 2028 (Expected)*

- Health-NLP Lab, Supervisor: Prof. Dr. Carsten Eickhoff.
- Scholar, International Max Planck Research School for Intelligent Systems (IMPRS-IS).
- Research focus: Interpretability of language models for NLP and IR tasks.
- Available for an internship from February 2027 for up to 6 months.

Moscow Institute of Physics and Technology — *Moscow, Russia*
***MSc** in Applied Mathematics and Computer Science* — *Sep 2021 – Jul 2024*

- Research topics: sparse retrieval, multimodal retrieval, tool calling in LLMs.
- Thesis: "Approaches to Training Language Models for External Function Calling: Using Self-Generated Data for Better Error Detection and Recovery".

***BSc** in Applied Mathematics and Computer Science* — *Sep 2017 – Jul 2021*

- Thesis: "Usage of MCMC Methods in Deep Learning".

Publications

Predicting Hallucinations Before, During, and After Generation with Sparse Autoencoder Features — *Under review*
***G. Polyakov**, A. Bahrainian, C. Eickhoff*

- Systematically studied hallucination detection from model internals before, during, and after generation in RAG and QA, showing a substantial signal before generation.
- Proposed PreSAGE, a trainable SAE-based detector with gated feature selection and attention pooling, best in 19 of 24 QA settings and the most consistent overall.

Understanding Wacky Weights: A Dissection of SPLADE's Learned Term Importance — *SIGIR 2026 (Reproducibility)*
***G. Polyakov**, H. Scells, C. Eickhoff*

- Introduced the Wackiness Score and W-AUC to quantify semantically unrelated expansion terms across models with different vocabularies and sparsity levels.
- Trained 6 SPLADE variants, showing that the prevalence of wacky weights increases with vocabulary size and that they mainly aid in-domain retrieval.

Interpretability Analysis of Arithmetic In-Context Learning in Large Language Models — *EMNLP 2025 (Main)*
***G. Polyakov**, C. Hepting, C. Eickhoff, A. Bahrainian*

- Identified the core computational pathway through which 4 LLMs (up to 12B) use in-context examples for multi-step arithmetic, from early-layer MLPs to the final token.
- Distilled in-context examples into a function vector that raises zero-shot accuracy by up to 25% absolute and fully recovers one-shot accuracy on Pythia-12B.

Towards Best Practices of Axiomatic Activation Patching in Information Retrieval — *SIGIR 2025 (Short)*
***G. Polyakov**, C. Chen, C. Eickhoff*

- Proposed a noise-mitigating evaluation metric for activation patching in neural rankers that filters out spurious low-confidence signals.
- Systematically analyzed diagnostic datasets, identifying key selection criteria for queries and documents to ensure robust interpretability analysis.

ToolReflection: Improving Large Language Models for Real-World API Calls with Self-Generated Data *ACL 2025 (REALM Workshop)*

***G. Polyakov**, I. Alimova, D. Abulkhanov, I. Sedykh, A. Bout, S. Nikolenko, I. Piontkovskaya*

- Fine-tuned 7B–13B LLMs (LLaMA, Vicuna) to self-correct API calls by learning from runtime execution feedback.
- Co-developed evaluation datasets for tool-augmented LLMs in more realistic scenarios.

Sinkhorn Transformations for Single-Query Postprocessing in Text-Video Retrieval *SIGIR 2023 (Short)*

*K. Yakovlev, **G. Polyakov**, I. Alimova, A. V. Podolskiy, A. Bout, S. I. Nikolenko, I. Piontkovskaya*

Work Experience

Huawei Noah's Ark Lab *Moscow, Russia*

NLP Research Engineer, full-time *Nov 2022 – Sep 2024*

- Developed a fine-tuning method that teaches LLMs to detect and recover from failed API calls (ACL 2025 REALM Workshop).
- Designed and co-implemented the end-to-end NLU pipeline for a production in-car voice assistant in Russian.
- Co-developed a Sinkhorn-based post-processing method that improves text-video retrieval quality (SIGIR 2023).

NLP Research Intern, full-time *Oct 2021 – Nov 2022*

- Co-developed the reranking model for a large-scale Russian-language product search engine: improved ranking quality by 5% relative NDCG@10 and cut inference latency 1.5x by adapting ColBERTer and TinyBERT-style distillation.

Invited Talks

Understanding Wacky Weights: A Dissection of SPLADE's Learned Term Importance *Oct 2026*

Glasgow IR Seminar, University of Glasgow

Funding & Scholarships

Presidential Grant Scholarship *Feb 2018 – Aug 2021*

Four-year stipend for academic and competition merit, one of 1,200 recipients nationwide.

Teaching Experience

University of Tübingen

Teaching Assistant, Introduction to AI *Winter Semester 2026/27*

- Conducted hands-on tutorials and evaluated student assignments.

Teaching Assistant, Modern Search Engines *Summer Semesters 2025, 2026*

- Conducted hands-on tutorials, evaluated assignments, and mentored student projects.

Teaching Assistant, Introduction to Python Programming *Winter Semesters 2024/25, 2025/26*

- Conducted hands-on tutorials and evaluated student assignments.

Skills

Programming: Python, C/C++, Bash.
ML & NLP: PyTorch, HF Transformers, PEFT, LLM fine-tuning (SFT, LoRA), reinforcement learning (GRPO), tool use, tabular foundation models (TabPFN).
Interpretability: TransformerLens, activation patching, steering, probing, sparse autoencoders, transcoders.
IR: Pyserini, FAISS, sparse and dense retrieval, neural ranking, RAG, knowledge distillation.
Infrastructure: SLURM, multi-GPU training (HF Accelerate), Git.